ISRO had the contract with SEP, and was not answerable to ESA, but SEP, as an agency that eventually came under ESA, had to consider the amendment. T N Seshan, India's master craftsman of contracts, was called in to negotiate. I accompanied Seshan to meet the SEP heads. Seshan was firm that the word 'peaceful' cannot be added to the contract.

'You will have to insist that the contract with India will remain intact, with no changes,' Seshan told SEP honchos.

When the SEP men insisted, Seshan said he would consult 'the highest office in India' and get back. The next day he was back at the negotiation table. 'The Government of India does not want any change to the contract. If this contract is annulled for this reason, we may have to review scores of other contracts we have with France,' Seshan said.

Now the ball was in SEP's court. They had to convince ESA that they could not afford to lose the many lucrative pacts France had with India. I don't know if Seshan ever spoke to 'the highest office in India', but SEP allowed the contract to remain the way it is. We were back at work in the SEP labs.

There were, however, more surprises. For one, the engineers in the seventy-five man year group were not put in the Viking technology section. There was no arguing with the French, so I decided to turn this into an advantage by getting five of our scientists as part of another crucial project SEP was working on—the HM7 cryogenic engine. Getting a glimpse of cryogenic development was a godsend, but we had some lessons to learn.

The members who worked with the French on HM7 brought documents and sketches associated with their work, and Unni religiously photocopied and stashed them away. How wrong were we, thinking that these papers would help us make a cryogenic engine. These files still gather dust in a safe in ISRO, and we got nothing out of it. This was the point I would tell my interrogators twenty years later: know-how does not help you make rockets, you need know-why. And this comes only with working with the masters for long years. My point: the case that I handed over drawings of rockets to Maldivian spies is a figment of imagination, a useless lie. If